MODULE 07 · DOMAIN 1 - PEOPLE

Building the team: charter, roles, ground rules

Turning a group of people into a team: shared agreements, clear roles, and knowing what stage the team is in.

DOMAIN I - People EXAM WEIGHT 33% MODULE 07 of 49

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A team is not people with the same deadline. It is people with **shared agreements**.

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The kickoff: the first chance to build the team

- Share the **purpose and vision**: why this project matters and what success looks like.
- Introduce **people and roles**, including who decides what.
- Start the **working agreements** the team will use, and plan how to finish them.
- For hybrid or distributed teams, bring everyone together, in person if at all possible.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> A good kickoff sets up the charter, the roles and the vision in one go. A missing kickoff shows up later as friction.

What goes in a team charter

SECTION	ANSWERS THE QUESTION
Values	What matters to us as a team?
Working agreements	How do we behave day to day?
Decision-making	How are decisions made, and by whom?
Communication	Which channels, how fast, and when?
Conflict process	What do we do when we disagree?
Meeting norms	When we meet, how do we run it?

ON THE EXAM

The charter is the team's own agreement about how it works. It is the first thing to consult when behaviour goes wrong.

Who writes it, and when

- The **team writes it together**. The project manager facilitates.
- Early: at or soon after the kickoff, before habits set.
- It is a **living document**: revisited when people join, when the work changes, or in retrospectives.
- A charter written by the project manager and handed out is a set of rules, not an agreement.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Ownership is the whole point. People keep agreements they helped make.

Team charter or project charter?

PROJECT CHARTER

Authorises the project

- Issued by the sponsor
- Formally starts the project
- Names the project manager and their authority
- High-level scope, objectives, risks

TEAM CHARTER

How the team works

- Created by the team
- Values and working agreements
- Decisions, communication, conflict
- Updated as the team changes

THE TIEBREAKER

Authority and objectives: project charter. Behaviour and working norms: team charter.

Ground rules that work

- **Specific and observable**: 'reply to direct messages within four working hours', not 'be responsive'.
- **Agreed by the team**, and few enough to remember.
- **Visible**: on the team board, or pinned in the team's channel.
- Vague rules like 'respect each other' cannot be kept or broken, so they cannot be enforced.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> If you cannot tell whether a rule was broken, it is not a ground rule yet. Make it observable.

When a ground rule is broken

01

Talk privately

Understand why. There may be a reason.

02

Refer to the agreement

The team's rule, not your preference.

03

Team revisits

If the rule does not work, change it together.

04

Escalate

Only if a pattern persists after all of this.

ON THE EXAM

The first move is always a private conversation. Public naming and immediate escalation both lose.

A RACI chart for Project Lantern

ACTIVITY	CLINIC MANAGER	PRODUCT OWNER	PROJECT MANAGER	KIOSK SUPPLIER
Define booking rules	C	A, R	I	–
Install kiosks	C	I	A	R
Clinic go-live decision	A	C	R	I
Train reception staff	R	C	A	I

ON THE EXAM

R does the work. A owns the outcome and signs off: exactly one per activity. C is asked. I is told.

RACI rules the exam uses

- **Exactly one A** per activity. Two accountable people means nobody is.
- At least one **R**, so someone actually does the work.
- Too many **C**s slow every decision; too many **I**s flood inboxes.
- Build it **with** the people named in it, and share it.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Two people who both think they approve something: the RACI has two A's, or does not exist. Fix that first.

Beyond the RACI

- **Role descriptions**: the role, its authority, its responsibilities, and the competence it needs.
- The **resource management plan** records how roles are staffed, developed and released.
- Organisation charts show reporting lines; the RACI shows who does what on the project.
- On agile teams, the accountabilities are fixed by the framework and the team decides the rest.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Authority must match responsibility. Someone responsible for a result needs the authority to achieve it.

How teams develop: Tuckman's stages

STAGE	WHAT YOU SEE	WHAT THE LEADER DOES
Forming	Polite, unsure, looking to the leader	Give direction, purpose and structure
Storming	Disagreement, friction, testing limits	Coach; surface and resolve conflict
Norming	Agreements settle, trust grows	Support; step back a little
Performing	Self-directed, effective, interdependent	Delegate; remove obstacles
Adjourning	Work ends, the team disbands	Recognise, reflect, release well

ON THE EXAM

Storming is normal, not failure. The leader's job is to help the team through it, not to stop it happening.

Tuckman on the exam

- **Storming is healthy**. A team that never disagrees has usually not engaged yet.
- Teams can **move backwards**: a new member, a new leader or a big change can return them to forming or storming.
- Teams can **stall** in a stage. A team stuck storming needs facilitated conflict resolution.
- **Adjourning** links to closure: recognise contributions and release people properly.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> A performing team that suddenly struggles after someone joins has moved back a stage. Re-form, don't blame.

Another view: the Drexler-Sibbet model

- Seven stages: **orientation, trust building, goal clarification, commitment**, then **implementation, high performance, renewal**.
- The first four create the team. The last three sustain it.
- Each stage has a question: why am I here, who are you, what are we doing, how will we do it?
- An unresolved early question, such as unclear goals, resurfaces later as poor performance.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> When a team underperforms, go back to the earliest question it has not answered. Often it is 'what are we doing?'.

Agile team composition

- **Cross-functional**: between them, every skill needed to deliver a finished increment.
- **Generalising specialists**, also called T-shaped people: deep in one skill, able to help in others.
- **Small, stable and dedicated**: moving people between teams costs productivity.
- When one skill becomes a bottleneck, others learn to help, rather than waiting in a queue.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> A single-specialist bottleneck is fixed by broadening skills in the team, not by adding a queue.

Onboarding someone new

- Walk them through the **charter, roles and vision**, then invite them to question it.
- Pair them with a **buddy**, and give them a clear, achievable first task.
- Let the team **revisit its agreements** with the newcomer included.
- Expect a short dip in performance. Plan for it rather than being surprised by it.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> A newcomer changes the team. Update the agreements together, rather than asking them simply to fit in.

Project Lantern: an extract from the team charter

- **Decisions:** technical choices by the developers; booking rules by the product owner; clinic dates by clinic managers.
- **Communication:** urgent issues by phone; everything else in the project channel, answered within half a day.
- **Meetings:** start on time, have an agenda, and end with decisions and owners written down.
- **Disagreement:** raise it with the person first, then at the retrospective, then with the project manager.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Short, specific and owned by the team. That is what a useful charter looks like.

Scenario signals and the team-building move

THE SCENARIO SAYS	THE MOVE
Nobody agrees how decisions are made	Facilitate a team charter
Two people both think they approve something	Clarify the RACI: one accountable person
Someone keeps breaking an agreed rule	Talk privately, refer to the agreement
New team, lots of arguing	Storming: facilitate, clarify roles and goals
Performing team struggles after a change	Moved back a stage: re-form together
Work queues behind one specialist	Cross-skill: others help and learn

ON THE EXAM

When a people problem appears, check first whether the agreement or role was ever clear.

> A team's charter says direct messages are answered within four working hours. One analyst routinely replies after two days, and colleagues have started complaining to the project manager.
>
> The analyst's work, when it arrives, is good.

What should the project manager do first?

A Raise the analyst's slow replies at the next team meeting, so everyone is clear on the rule.

B Report the analyst's behaviour to their functional manager.

C Speak to the analyst privately, refer to the agreement, and find out what is causing the delay.

D Remove the response-time rule, since the analyst's work is good anyway.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do first?

A Raise it at the team meeting.

Singles out one person in public. Damages trust and causes defensiveness.

B Report to the functional manager.

Escalation before a single conversation has happened.

C Private talk, refer to the agreement, find the cause.

Rung 1, privately: the delay may have a fixable cause, like workload or notifications.

D Drop the rule.

Changes the team's agreement unilaterally, and ignores colleagues' complaints.

THE SIGNAL

A broken ground rule: private conversation first, anchored on the team's own agreement.

> Three weeks into a new project, team members argue frequently about technical approaches and who should do what. Meetings overrun, and little is decided.
>
> Two team members have told the project manager they are frustrated and wonder if the team will work.

What should the project manager do?

A Treat this as a normal stage of development, and facilitate discussions to clarify roles and agree approaches.

B Separate the people who argue most onto different work packages.

C Ask human resources to mediate between the team members.

D Make the technical and role decisions to end the arguments quickly.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A Normal stage; facilitate roles and approaches.
Storming is expected. Facilitation moves the team towards norming.

B Separate the arguers.
Avoids the conflict, so it never resolves and the team never forms.

C Ask HR to mediate.
Treats a normal team stage as a personnel problem. Too far, too soon.

D Decide everything.
Ends the arguments but takes ownership away, and skips building agreements.

THE SIGNAL

New team, frequent disagreement about roles and approach: storming. Facilitate through it.

> On a building fit-out, the client's facilities manager and its finance director both believe they approve design changes.
>
> They have approved contradictory changes twice this month, and the contractor has had to rework completed work.

What should the project manager do?

A Follow whichever approval arrives most recently.

B Ask the contractor to stop work until the two managers agree.

C Work with the sponsor and both managers to agree one accountable approver for design changes, and record it.

D Let the design team decide which approvals to follow.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A. Latest approval wins.
Keeps the contradiction and the rework going, just more randomly.

B. Stop the contractor.
Halts all work, costing time and money, without fixing who decides.

C. Agree one accountable approver, and record it.
Fixes the root cause: two A's for one activity.

D. Design team decides.
Puts the team between two senior stakeholders, deciding something that is not theirs.

THE SIGNAL

Two people who both approve the same thing: the RACI has two A's. One accountable person per activity.

> An agile team of seven has one tester. Developers finish items early in each iteration, then the items queue for testing, and several miss the iteration.
>
> The tester works long hours and is close to exhaustion.

What should the project leader do?

A Help the team spread testing skills, with developers pairing with the tester and taking on testing work.

B Request a second tester from the resource manager.

C Ask the tester to work extra hours near the end of each iteration.

D Reduce the amount of testing so items finish on time.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project leader do?

A Spread testing skills; pair with the tester.

Cross-skilling removes the queue, protects the tester, and fits agile team design.

B Request a second tester.

Possible later, but adds cost and keeps a handoff queue in place.

C More overtime.

The tester is already near exhaustion. Unsustainable, and it breaks an agile principle.

D Test less.

Trades quality for speed, and defects will cost more later.

THE SIGNAL

Work queues behind one specialist while others wait: broaden skills in the team.

A high-performing team gains a new senior engineer from another department. Within two weeks, meetings become tense and the team's throughput drops.

The newcomer questions several of the team's working practices, and some members feel criticised.

What should the project manager do?

A Ask the new engineer to adapt to the team's existing way of working.

B Ask the resource manager to move the new engineer to another team.

C Tell the team to ignore the criticism and keep working as before.

D Facilitate a session where the team, including the newcomer, revisits its working agreements.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A. Newcomer must adapt.
Ignores that the team has changed, and dismisses possibly useful ideas.

B. Move the newcomer.
Removing people after two weeks was a losing answer. Nothing has been tried.

C. Ignore the criticism.
Suppresses the conflict. It will return, larger.

D. Revisit the agreements together.
The team has moved back a stage. Re-forming with the newcomer included fixes it.

THE SIGNAL

A performing team struggling after someone joins has moved back a stage. Re-form, together.

> Two months into a project, a team spread across two offices keeps reopening decisions made in earlier meetings.
>
> People arrive unprepared, and several say they are unsure who is entitled to make which decisions.

What should the project manager have done to prevent this?

A. Required weekly written status reports from every team member.

B. Facilitated a team charter at the start, covering decision-making and meeting norms.

C. Supervised team meetings more closely to stop decisions being reopened.

D. Escalated the reopened decisions to the sponsor for a final ruling.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager have done to prevent this?

A Weekly status reports.

Adds reporting. Does nothing about who decides or how meetings run.

B A team charter at the start.

Agrees decision rights and meeting norms before friction appears.

C Closer supervision.

Control instead of agreement. The confusion about decision rights remains.

D Escalate the decisions.

Reactive, and pushes team decisions onto the sponsor.

THE SIGNAL

'Should have done' plus confusion about who decides: the missing piece was a team charter.

Agree how you work. Make roles clear.
Expect storming, and facilitate through it.